BERNSTEIN
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US Communications Infrastructure

Data Centers: What a top-tier data center market looks like—including the DLR and EQIX footprints

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We're fielding a lot of questions on data center buildouts, at least in part driven by the daily headlines on power delays, NIMBYism, and supply chain constraints. Most of our answers boil down to "it depends on what market(s) you're looking at - we feel pretty good about Major Metros and the players building / buying there". In this note, we do a comparison of market types and a deep dive into three of the top U.S. markets.

We think of three data center market archetypes: Major Metro markets (typically considered the top 8-10 in North America), Minor Metro markets (sometimes thought of as Tiers 2-4, smaller cities or the extreme outskirts of Major Metros), and Rural markets. **The two public data center company footprints, DLR (OP, $232) and EQIX (OP, $1,222) are overwhelmingly concentrated in Major and Minor Metros; they are among the most insulated from market noise.**

Major Metros are and will continue to be the most important markets for latency-sensitive use cases (including inferencing), as well as enterprise colocation. These markets are well established and hard to build in. Power queues are long, build costs are high, and supply chains are tight. Existing capacity and in-progress, permitted builds are valuable. We are seeing an increase in NIMBYism in these markets, particularly NoVa and Phoenix, in part driven by rising power costs. We believe the established builders will manage this appropriately, but it is an emerging risk.

After Major Metros, overflow goes into Minor Metros. This works where there is marginally less latency sensitivity and/or marginally more price sensitivity. There has been significant growth in these markets over the last ~5 years, which we anticipate continuing.

Finally, training, latency-insensitive, and/or very price sensitive workloads take place in Rural markets. These markets tend to have larger facilities, more speculative builds, and less experienced developers than Major Metros. On the positive side, there is faster power availability and lower cost to build. On the negative side, there is not as clear visibility to sustained demand.

In the U.S., the biggest data center market is Northern Virginia (NoVa), which has ~8GW of supply today, ~5GW under construction, and power queues reportedly in the seven-year range. Pricing in NoVa has only gone up over the last several years, currently around $217/KW/mo, with vacancy stable below 1%. While there has been some recent news around the Digital Gateway Project (QTS and Compass), this market is typically a well-oiled machine.

This quarter, both DLR and EQIX spoke about large hyperscale-focused builds outside of Atlanta, another top U.S. data center market growing quickly (~2GW today, ~3GW under construction). Atlanta pricing is $175/KW/mo today, with vacancy around 2%. We like this strategy - market dynamics are favorable, both DLR and EQIX are savvy builders with strong, experienced teams in the Major Metros, and relatively limited execution risk. **We remain positive on both DLR and EQIX, believing both companies will deliver on their build projections given their Major Metro market exposure.**

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BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	Cur	14 May 2026 Closing Price	Price Target	TTM Rel. Perf.	Adjusted EPS Cur	Adjusted EPS 2025A	Adjusted EPS 2026E	Adjusted EPS 2027E	Adjusted P/E (x) 2025A	Adjusted P/E (x) 2026E	Adjusted P/E (x) 2027E
DLR (Digital Realty)	O	USD	192.84	232.00	(10.9)%	USD	3.87	2.74	2.37	49.8	70.5	81.2
EQIX (Equinix)	O	USD	1,079.68	1,222.00	(1.6)%	USD	14.96	17.88	21.36	72.2	60.4	50.5
SPX			7,501.24									

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

INVESTMENT IMPLICATIONS

We value DLR on a Price to Adjusted Funds from Operations (AFFO) per share multiple. Our $232 price target is based on 27x our 2027E AFFO per share of $8.60.

We value EQIX on a Price to Adjusted Funds From Operations (AFFO) per share multiple. Our $1,222 price target is based on 25x our 2027E AFFO per share of $48.63

DETAILS

A DEEP DIVE INTO THE TOP U.S. MARKETS

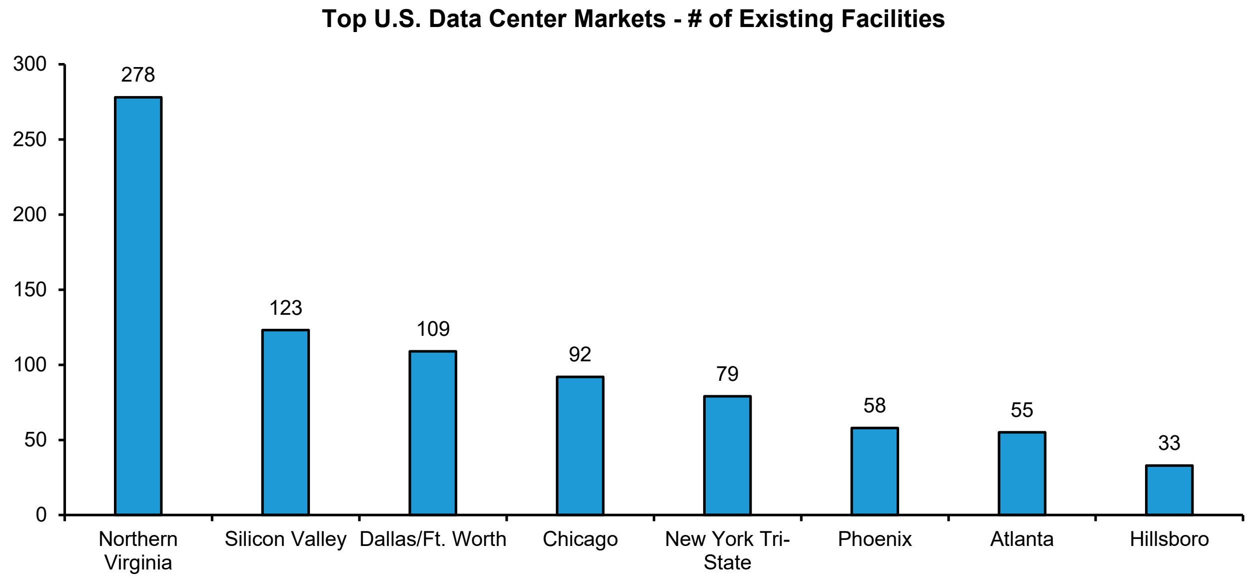
The three market archetypes are essentially based on how developers and customers trade off latency vs. power availability vs. cost—with urban markets optimizing for proximity, rural markets optimizing for scale and power, and secondary markets sitting in between as an equilibrium zone. We see a clear gradient across data center market tiers: **Major Metros** are optimized for latency-sensitive inference and enterprise colocation, with the highest pricing ($120–150/kW hyperscale, $160–230 colo), highest build costs ($12–15B per GW), tightest cap rates (≈4.5–6.5%), and the longest power delays (4–7 years), while **Minor Metros** sit in the middle with slightly lower pricing, costs, and delays but higher yields; in contrast, **Rural markets** are primarily focused on large-scale AI training, offering the lowest costs ($7–9B per GW), fastest power availability (1–3 years), and cheapest hyperscale pricing ($70–120/kW), but also the highest cap rates (≈6.5–9%+) and minimal colocation presence—leading to a broader industry shift where growth and new capacity increasingly migrate from constrained urban hubs to lower-cost, power-rich rural regions.

EXHIBIT 1: **Comparing Tiers of Data Center Markets**

	Major Metro	Minor Metro	Rural
Use Cases	**Inference, Enterprise Colo**	**Inference, Enterprise Colo**	**Training**
Hyperscale Pricing	$120-150	$90-130	$70-120
Colo Pricing	$160-230	$150-190	-
Estimated Size Today (U.S. GW)	**21.5**	**23.6**	**23.6**
Estimated Planned (U.S. GW)	**25.7**	**26.1**	**37.0**
Build Costs per GW	$12-15B	$9-12B	$7-9B
Hyperscale Cap Rates	**4.5-6.0%**	**5.5-6.75%**	**6.5-8.0%**
Colo Cap Rates	**5.5-6.5%**	**6.0-7.25%**	**7.0-9.0%**
Power Queues	4-7 years	3-5 years	1-3 years
Development Risk	Med (zoning, local pushback)	Med (zoning, local pushback)	Low

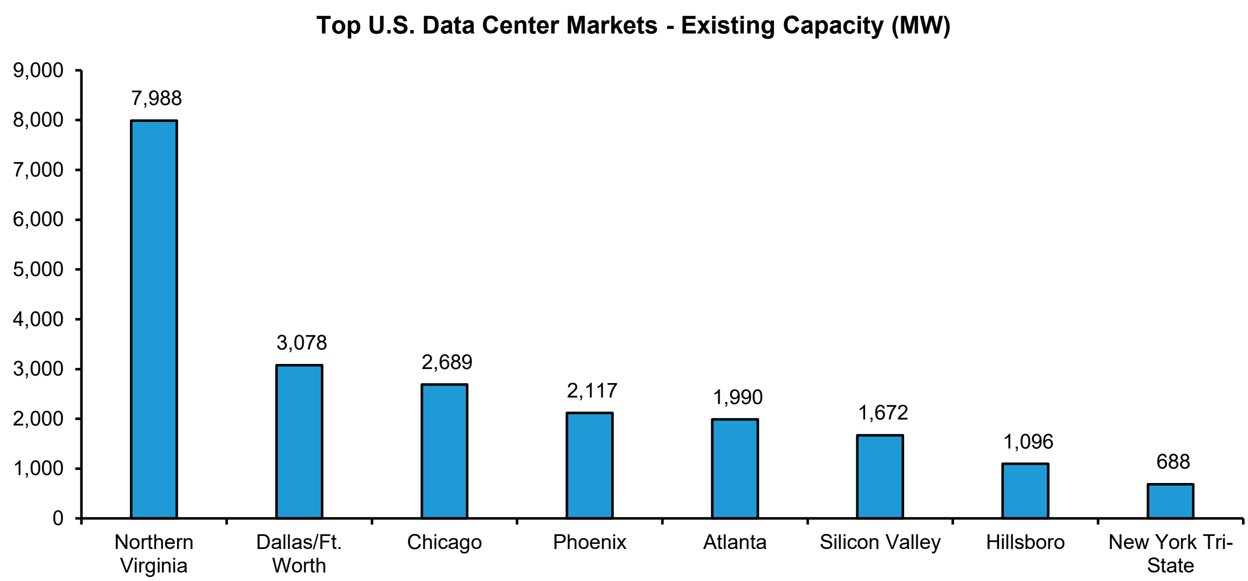
Source: Omdia, CBRE, JLL, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 2: **NoVA, the Bay Area, and Dallas/Ft. Worth have the most existing facilities today**



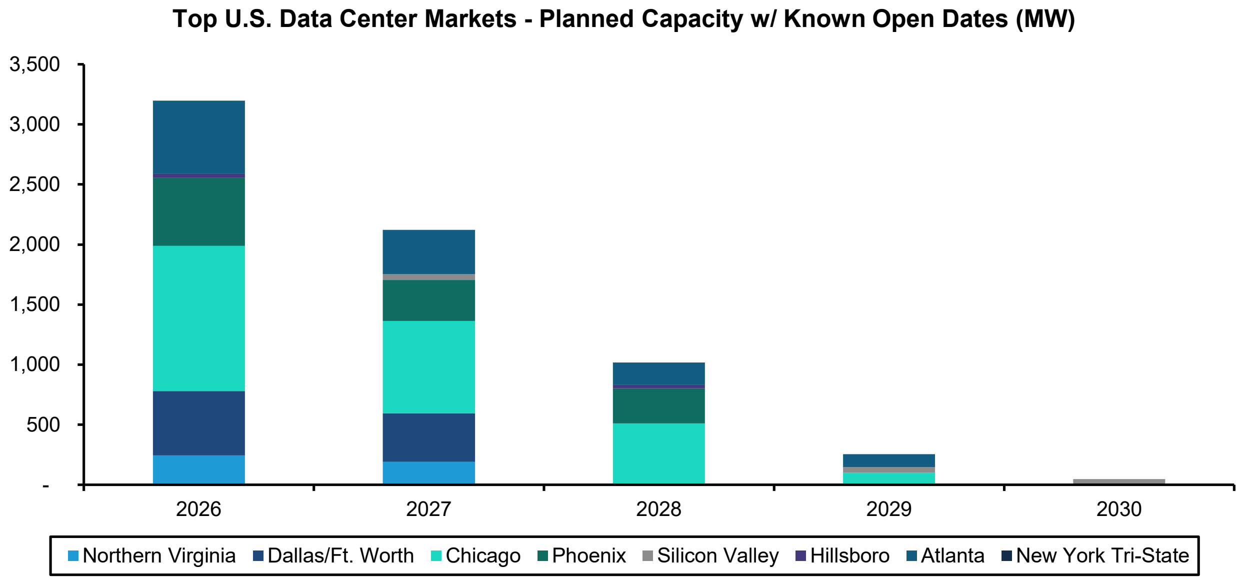
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 3: **... while NoVA, Dallas/Ft. Worth, and the Chicago metro area have the most capacity today**



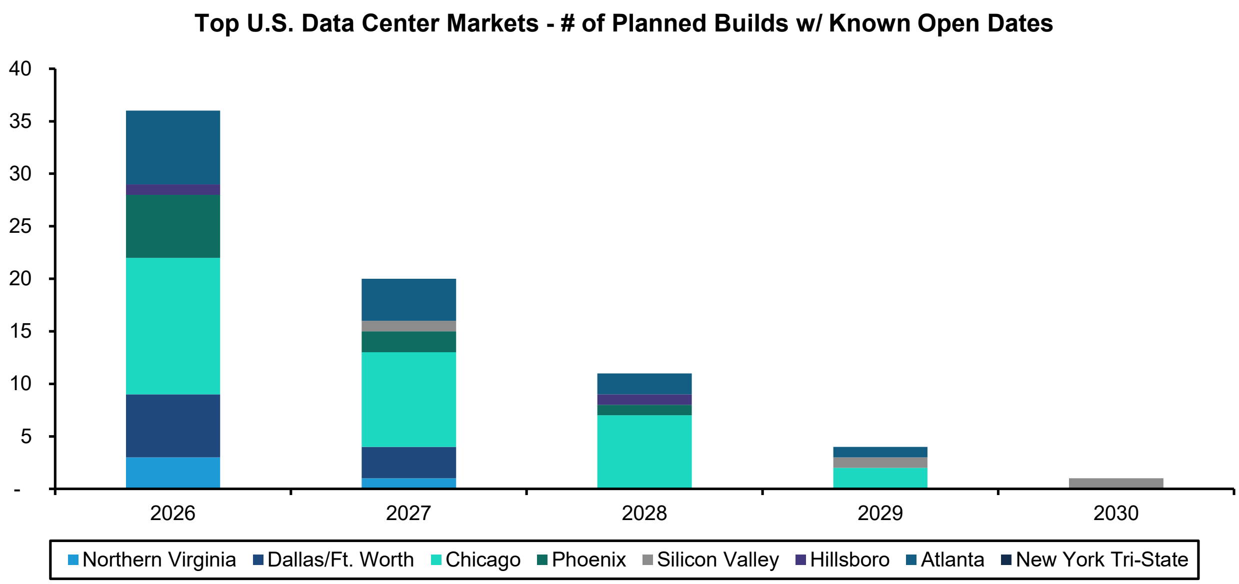
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 4: **Chicago, Atlanta, and Phoenix are expected to gain the most capacity over 2026-2030**



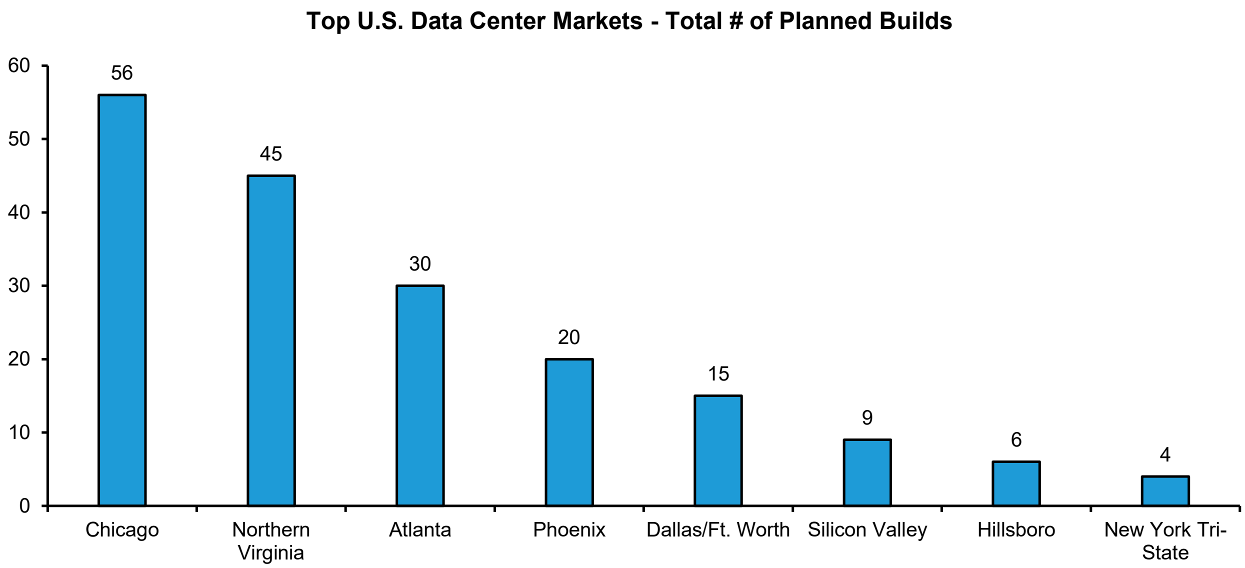
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 5: **... as well as the greatest increase in number of facilities**



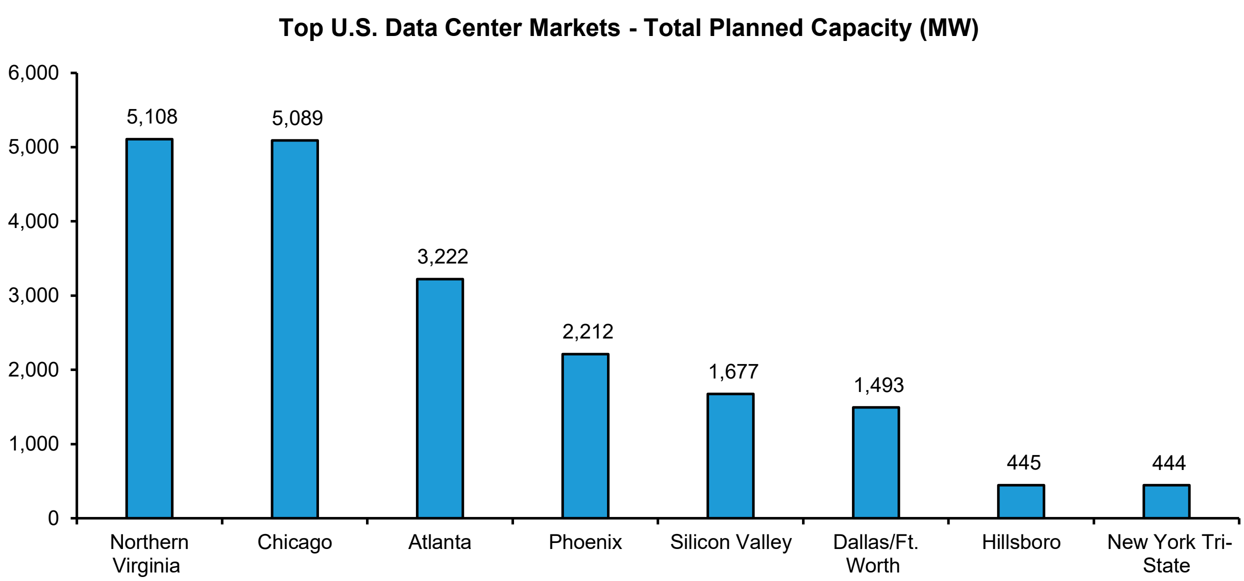
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 6: **Chicago, NoVA, and Atlanta have the most number of planned builds, including planned builds with unknown open dates**



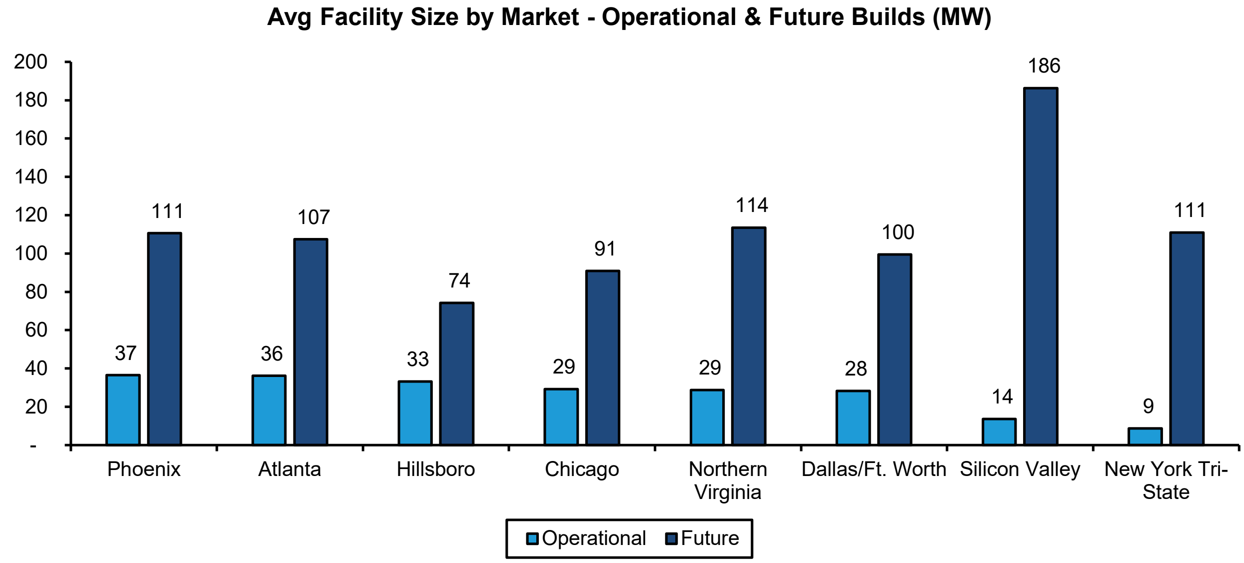
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 7: **... as well as the most planned capacity, with ~5GW in both NoVA and Chicago, and >3GW in Atlanta**



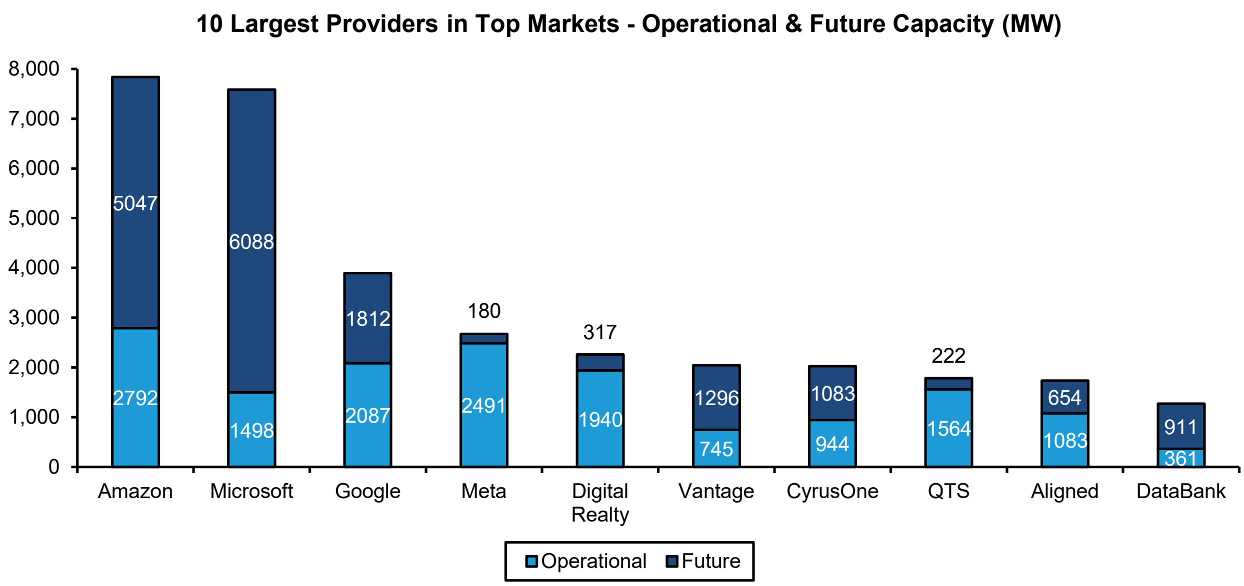
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 8: **Across the top 8 markets we have identified, the average existing facility is 27 MW versus 112 MW for planned builds, or >4x more capacity**



Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 9: **While the largest current providers are Amazon, Meta, Google, and Digital Realty, Amazon and Microsoft have the most ambitious capacity expansion plans, each with 5-6 GW slotted**

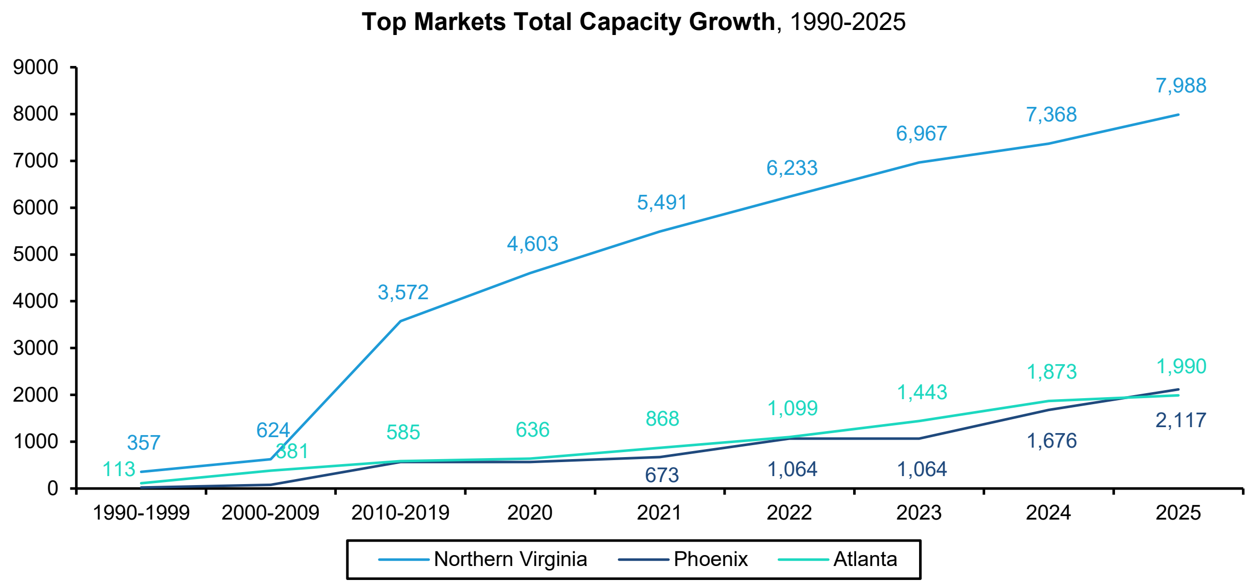


Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

INDIVIDUAL MARKET SNAPSHOTS: COMPARING NOVA, PHOENIX, AND ATLANTA

Northern Virginia (NoVA), Phoenix, and Atlanta illustrate three distinct archetypes within the U.S. data center landscape, each shaped by a different balance of power availability, cost, and ecosystem maturity. **NoVA** remains the dominant global hub, characterized by unmatched scale, dense interconnection, and hyperscale concentration—supporting premium pricing, the lowest cap rates, and the tightest supply conditions, but also facing the longest power timelines and highest barriers to entry. **Phoenix** represents a power-advantaged growth market, attracting large hyperscale deployments due to relatively lower costs and more available land, with rising importance as an alternative to constrained Tier 1 hubs, though with less network density and ecosystem depth than NoVA. **Atlanta**, meanwhile, sits in between as a rapidly scaling secondary hub that combines proximity to enterprise demand with improving power access and economics, increasingly capturing spillover from primary markets while maintaining a more balanced profile across pricing, growth, and development risk.

EXHIBIT 10: **NoVA is the largest and most developed market by far, with a much earlier ramp starting in 2000-2009, though Phoenix and Atlanta are currently the fastest-growing**



Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

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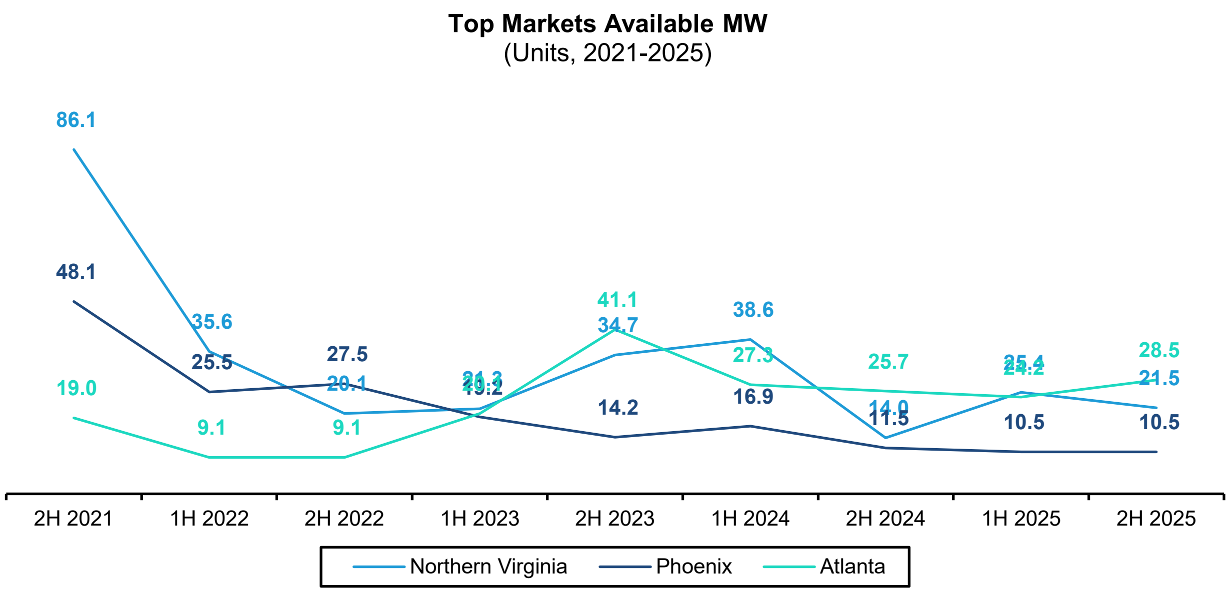
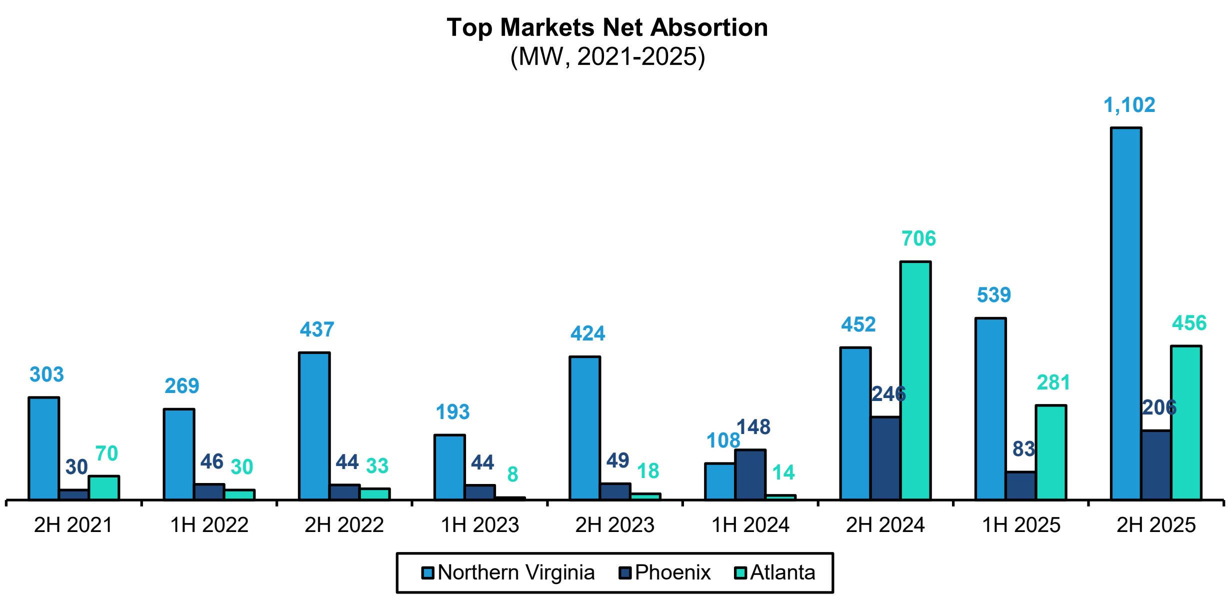
EXHIBIT 11: **The top three markets have seen a consistent decline in available capacity, as rising demand continues to absorb and secure newly delivered supply**



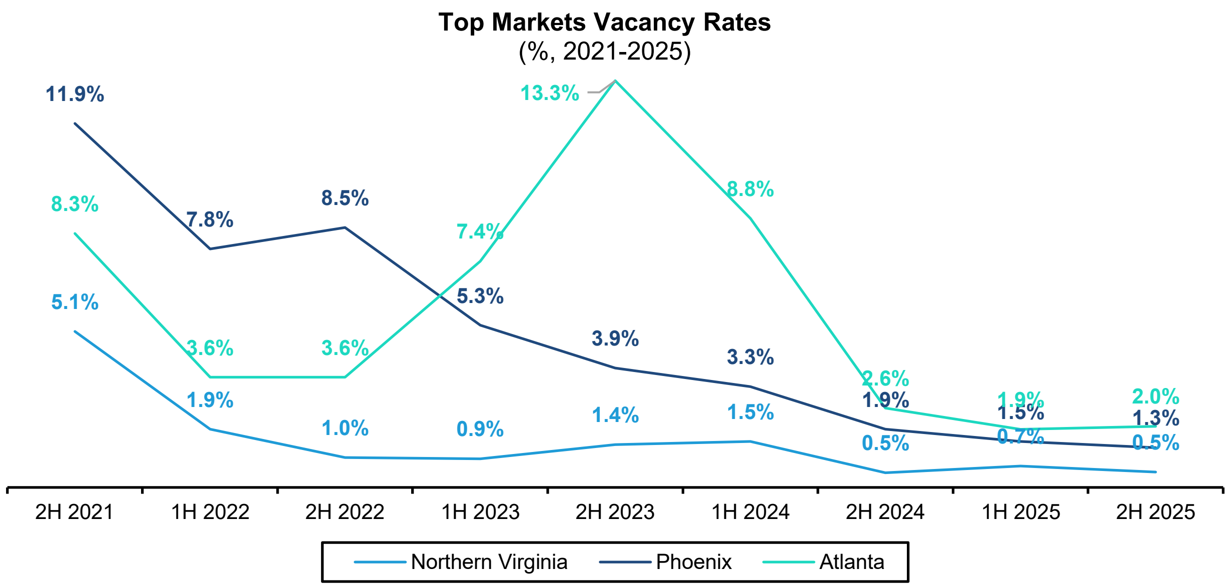
Source: CBRE North America Data Center Trends, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 12: **NoVA stands out as the most prominent market in terms of net absorption, reflecting strong demand for the segment. Similarly, Atlanta has been gaining momentum since 2024, while Phoenix continues to grow at a steady pace**



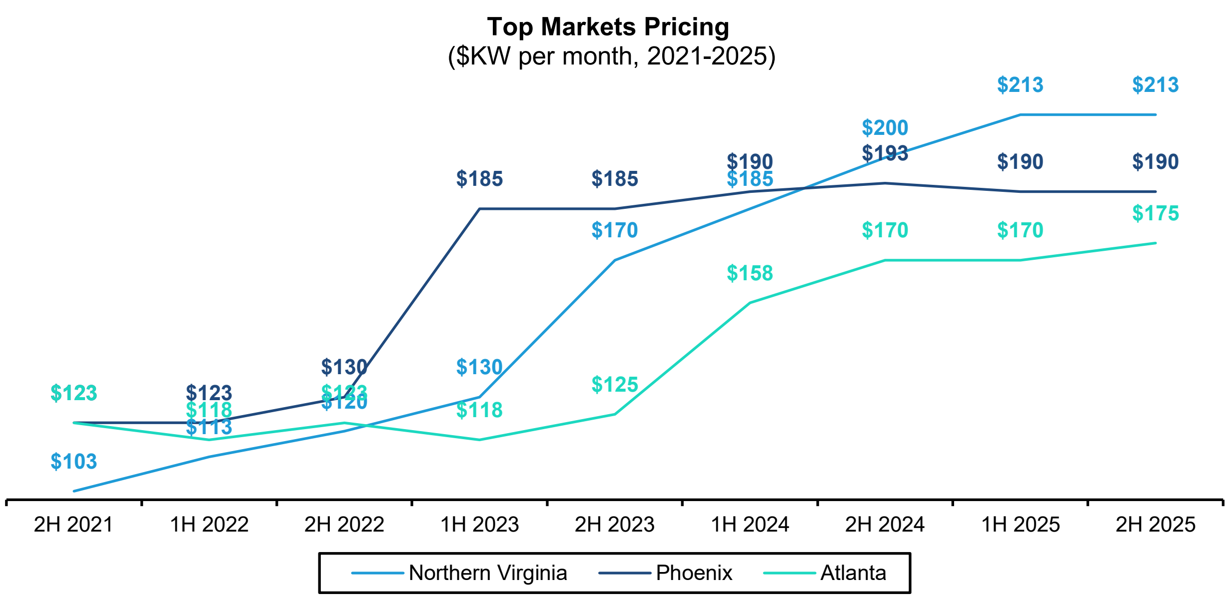
Source: CBRE North America Data Center Trends, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 13: **Vacancy rates in top markets have significantly declined due to strong demand growth, reaching notably low levels of approximately 1%–2%**



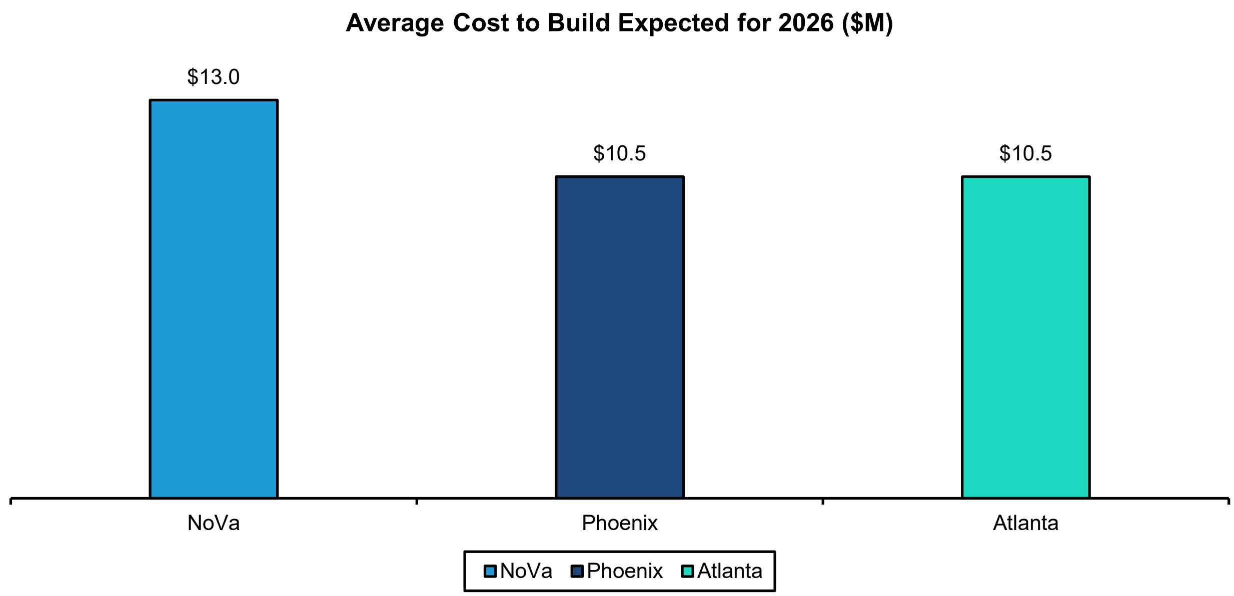
Source: CBRE North America Data Center Trends, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 14: **Across the three markets, the average four-year CAGR is 13%, reflecting strong demand, with Phoenix the most stable since 2023.**



Source: CBRE North America Data Center Trends, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 15: **Phoenix and Atlanta stand out as the most cost-efficient data center markets, while NoVA remains the most expensive, reflecting its stronger demand and leading market position.**

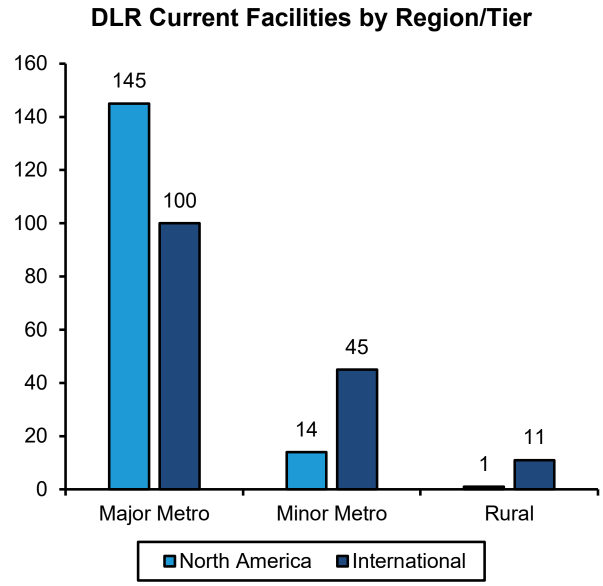


Source: JLL Global DC Outlook, Bernstein Analysis

DLR AND EQIX - HOW DO THEIR RESPECTIVE FOOTPRINTS STACK UP?

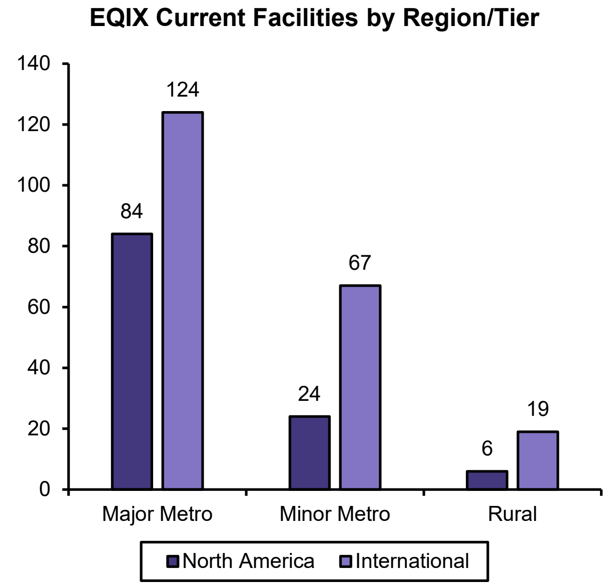
Digital Realty (DLR) and Equinix (EQIX) illustrate two distinct approaches to global data center deployment that map closely to the tiering framework: DLR has built a broader footprint across both primary and emerging markets, with a strong emphasis on hyperscale and hybrid offerings that extend into secondary and power-rich regions, while EQIX remains more tightly concentrated in Tier 1, highly interconnected urban hubs where enterprise colocation, network density, and proximity to end users drive pricing power. DLR typically operates larger campuses and buildings often ranging from ~20 MW to 100+ MW per facility (and even larger at the campus level), geared toward hyperscale and wholesale deployments, whereas EQIX facilities are generally smaller, denser, and more modular, often averaging ~5 MW to 25 MW per site, optimized for multi-tenant colo and interconnection density. As a result, DLR tends to capture growth in large-scale, cost-optimized deployments alongside hyperscalers, whereas EQIX maintains a premium position in core metros, leveraging its dense interconnection ecosystem and enterprise customer base.

EXHIBIT 16: **DLR's presence leans more heavily towards major metro areas, especially in North America**



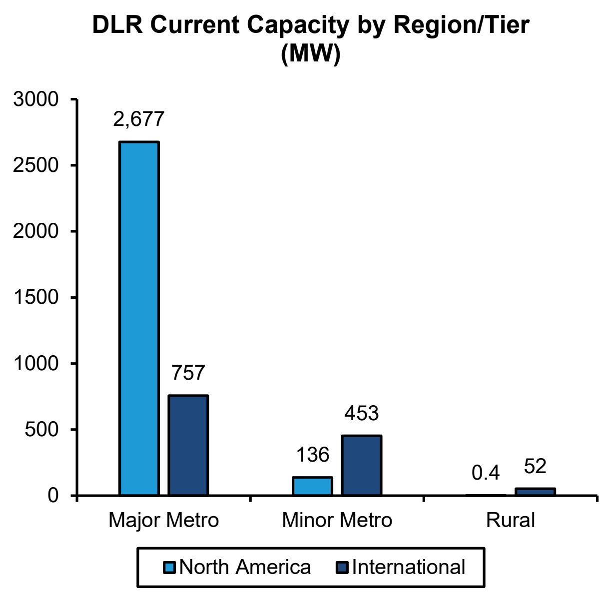
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 17: **EQIX has greater exposure to minor metro and rural markets than DLR, but major metros still represent the largest share**



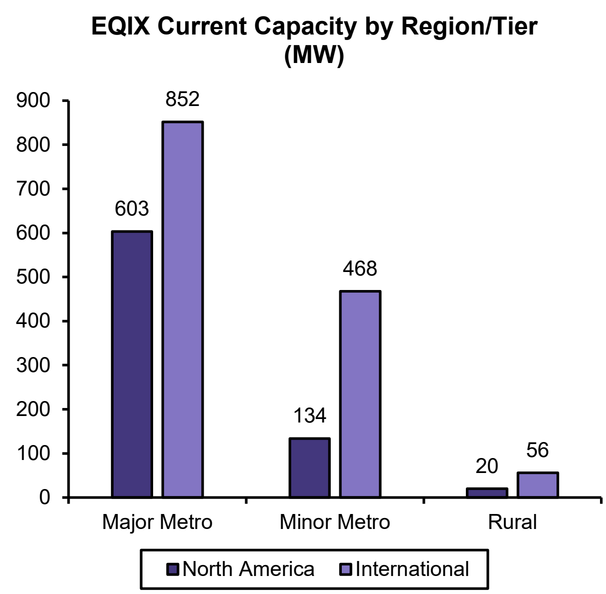
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 18: **The same goes for on a capacity basis, as DLR's North America footprint is ~95% in major metro areas**



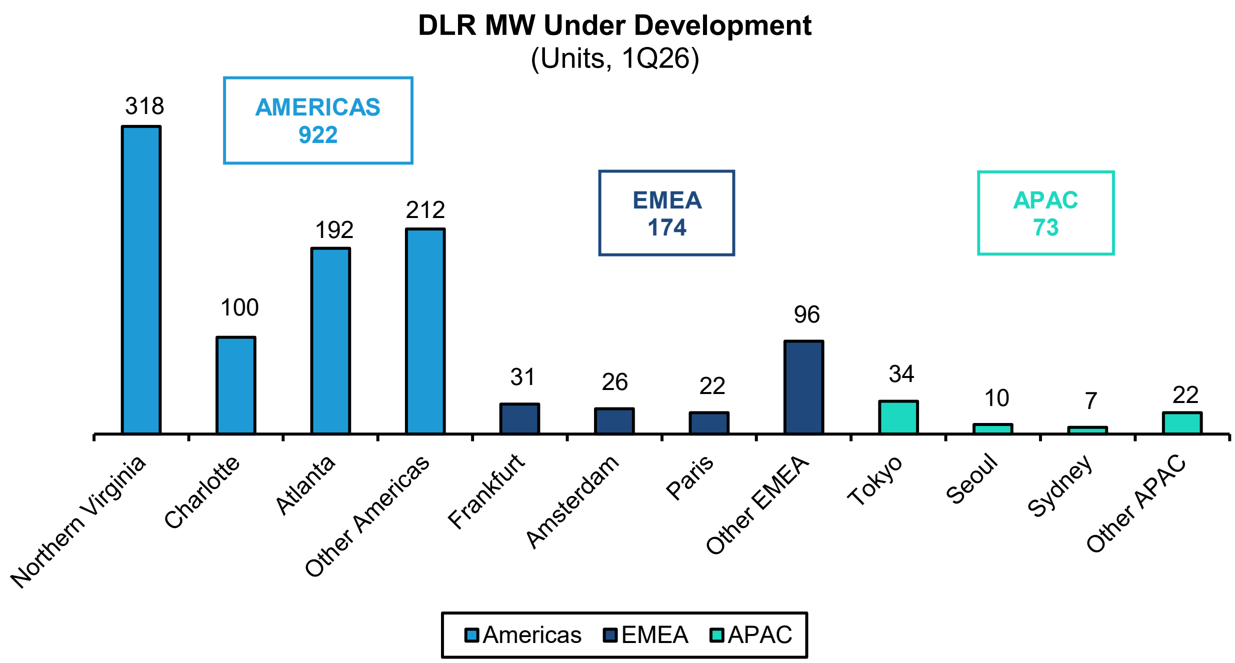
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 19: **Unlike DLR, EQIX's capacity leans more heavily towards international, especially EMEA**



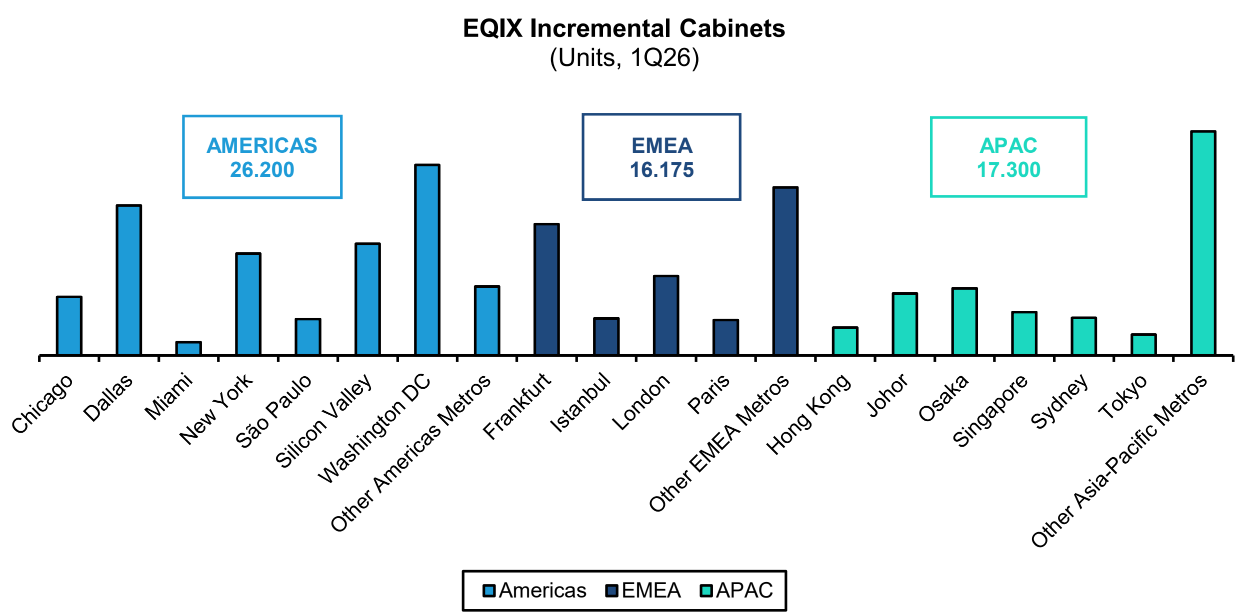
Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 20: **DLR MW Under Development (1Q26)**



Company filings, Bernstein Analysis

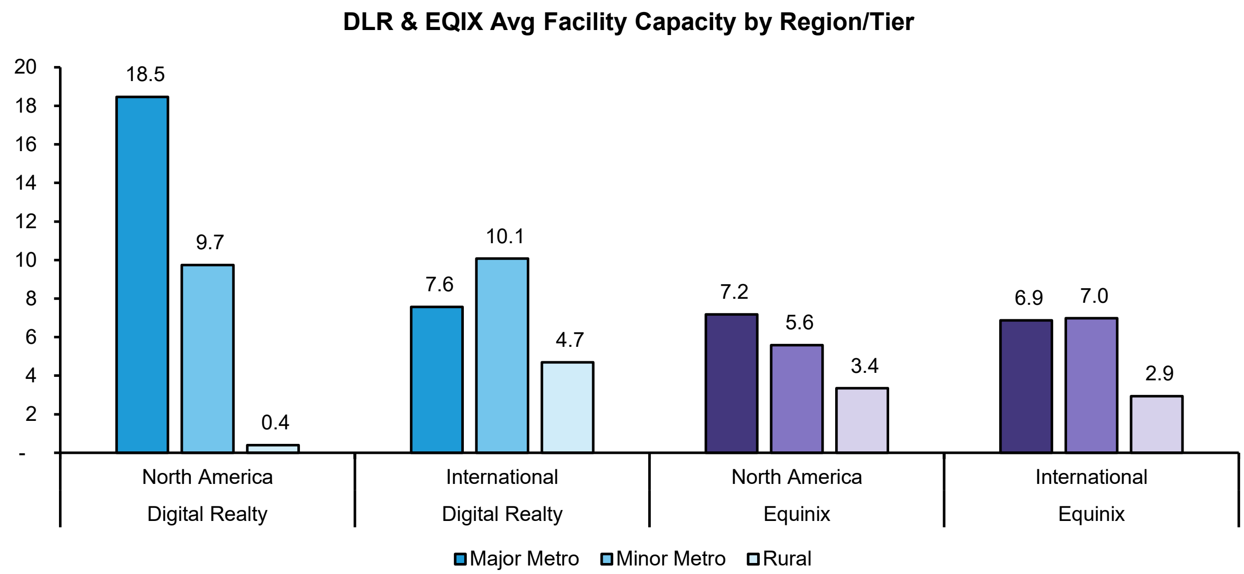
EXHIBIT 21: **EQIX Incremental Cabinets (1Q26)**



Does not include xScale

Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis

EXHIBIT 22: **Both DLR and EQIX tend to have facilities with larger capacities in major metro regions vs rural, and the effect is more pronounced for North America than for International**



Source: Omdia, Bernstein analysis

APPENDIX - FINANCIAL FORECASTS

EXHIBIT 23: **DLR Income Statement Overview**

All values in millions, except per share data

	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	1Q27E	FY 2025	FY 2026	FY 2027	FY 2028	FY 2029
Rental revenues	1,004	1,046	1,075	1,104	1,124	1,162	1,201	1,233	4,084	4,591	5,158	5,759	6,428
Tenant reimbursement - utilities	295	333	356	334	342	376	401	374	1,254	1,452	1,633	1,823	2,035
Tenant reimbursement - other	37	37	34	38	37	35	34	33	151	144	124	130	145
Interconnection & Others	122	120	123	124	133	137	142	146	479	536	609	687	773
Rental and other services revenue	1,457	1,536	1,589	1,600	1,635	1,710	1,778	1,785	5,969	6,723	7,524	8,399	9,380
Fee income	34	36	46	35	35	35	35	35	137	140	140	140	140
Other	1	5	0	0	2	2	2	2	7	6	8	8	8
Fee income and other	36	41	46	35	37	37	37	37	144	146	148	148	148
Total operating revenues	1,493	1,577	1,635	1,635	1,672	1,747	1,815	1,822	6,113	6,869	7,672	8,547	9,528
Total operating expenses	1,281	1,439	1,522	1,368	1,423	1,485	1,557	1,512	5,454	5,833	6,411	6,983	7,572
Operating income	212	138	113	267	249	262	258	310	658	1,035	1,261	1,563	1,956
Income before taxes	1,060	75	86	191	281	294	288	221	1,345	1,054	901	1,178	1,552
Income tax expense	(13)	(12)	10	(16)	(24)	(25)	(24)	(25)	(32)	(88)	(63)	(88)	(109)
Net income (loss)	1,047	64	96	175	258	269	264	197	1,313	966	838	1,090	1,443
Net loss (income) attributable to noncontrolling interests	(15)	4	3	4	-	-	-	-	(5)	4	-	-	-
Net income attributable to Digital Realty Trust Inc.	1,032	68	99	179	258	269	264	197	1,309	970	838	1,090	1,443
Preferred stock dividends	(10)	(10)	(10)	(10)	(10)	(10)	(10)	(10)	(41)	(41)	(41)	(41)	(41)
Gain (loss) on redemption of preferred stock	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Net income available to common stockholders	1,022	58	88	169	248	259	254	187	1,268	929	798	1,049	1,402
(+) Adjustments	-	-	79	-	12	12	12	13	79	37	53	53	37
Adjusted Net Income	1,022	58	167	169	260	271	266	199	1,346	966	850	1,102	1,439
Earnings per share (EPS)													
EPS (basic)	3.03	0.17	0.26	0.49	0.72	0.75	0.73	0.54	3.73	2.69	2.28	2.95	3.88
EPS (diluted)	2.96	0.17	0.25	0.48	0.70	0.73	0.72	0.52	3.65	2.63	2.23	2.88	3.79
Adjusted EPS (diluted)	2.96	0.17	0.48	0.48	0.73	0.77	0.75	0.56	3.87	2.74	2.37	3.02	3.89
Adjusted FFO (AFFO) per share (basic)	1.71	1.79	1.37	1.95	1.87	1.86	1.83	2.12	6.67	7.53	8.52	9.07	10.33

Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

EXHIBIT 24: **EQIX Income Statement Overview**

All values in millions, except per share data

	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	1Q27E	FY 2025	FY 2026	FY 2027	FY 2028	FY 2029
Recurring Revenues	2,143	2,215	2,294	2,331	2,444	2,473	2,501	2,596	8,739	9,749	10,727	12,017	13,800
Non-Recurring Revenues	113	101	126	113	128	130	132	137	478	503	565	634	728
Total Revenues	2,256	2,316	2,420	2,444	2,573	2,603	2,633	2,732	9,217	10,252	11,293	12,650	14,528
Cost of revenues	1,084	1,142	1,198	1,186	1,256	1,266	1,274	1,312	4,508	4,983	5,370	5,877	6,479
Gross profit	1,172	1,174	1,222	1,258	1,316	1,337	1,358	1,421	4,709	5,270	5,923	6,774	8,049
Total operating expenses	678	700	800	681	748	752	757	779	2,861	2,937	3,279	3,673	4,218
Income from operations	494	474	422	577	568	586	601	642	1,848	2,333	2,644	3,101	3,831
Income before income taxes	405	399	312	471	454	470	486	521	1,508	1,880	2,140	2,512	3,237
Income tax expense	(38)	(25)	(48)	(56)	(57)	(59)	(61)	(65)	(160)	(232)	(267)	(314)	(405)
xScale contribution to Net income	-	-	-	-	42	42	42	66	-	125	263	345	452
Net income	367	374	264	415	439	453	467	521	1,348	1,773	2,135	2,543	3,285
Net (income) / loss attributable to non-controlling interests	1	-	1	-	-	-	-	-	2	-	-	-	-
Net income attributable to common stockholders	368	374	265	415	439	453	467	521	1,350	1,773	2,135	2,543	3,285
(+) Adjustments	6	11	85	(4)	-	-	-	-	118	(4)	-	-	-
Adjusted Net Income	374	385	350	411	439	453	467	521	1,468	1,769	2,135	2,543	3,285
Earnings per share (EPS)													
EPS (basic)	3.76	3.82	2.70	4.22	4.45	4.58	4.71	5.25	13.79	17.97	21.44	25.30	32.39
EPS (diluted)	3.75	3.81	2.69	4.20	4.43	4.56	4.69	5.23	13.76	17.92	21.36	25.21	32.28
Adjusted EPS (diluted)	3.81	3.92	3.56	4.16	4.43	4.56	4.69	5.23	14.96	17.88	21.36	25.21	32.28
Adjusted FFO (AFFO) per share (basic)	9.94	9.85	8.93	10.82	11.23	11.21	10.78	12.40	38.42	44.09	48.63	54.09	62.97

Source: Company filings, Bernstein Analysis and Estimates

DISCLOSURE APPENDIX

I. REQUIRED DISCLOSURES

References to "Bernstein" or the “Firm” in these disclosures relate to the following entities: Bernstein Institutional Services LLC (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein & Co., LLC (pre April 1, 2024), Bernstein Autonomous LLP, BSG France S.A. (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein (Hong Kong) Limited 盛博香港有限公司, Sanford C. Bernstein (Canada) Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein (India) Private Limited (SEBI registration no. INH000006378), Sanford C. Bernstein (Singapore) Private Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein Japan KK（サンフォード・C・バーンスタイン株式会社）and analysts employed by Société Générale Africa Technologies & Services to produce Bernstein research under a Global Services Agreement in place between Bernstein and Société Générale.

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VALUATION METHODOLOGY

Digital Realty Trust, Inc.

We value DLR on a Price to Adjusted Funds From Operations (AFFO) per share multiple. Our $232 price target is based on 27x our 2027E AFFO per share of $8.52.

Equinix, Inc.

We value EQIX on a Price to Adjusted Funds From Operations (AFFO) per share multiple. Our $1,222 price target is based on 25x our 2027E AFFO per share of $48.63.

RISKS

Digital Realty Trust, Inc.

The main downside risks to our price target/Outperform rating on DLR are 1) Lower than expected growth in the <1MW segment, 2) Slowdown in enterprise demand for data center capacity, and 3) Continuing decline in market share of data center supply may elevate pricing pressures

Equinix, Inc.

The main downside risks to our price target/Outperform rating on EQIX are 1) Slowdown in enterprise demand for data center capacity, 2) Increased competition in the interconnection space, and 3) Continuing decline in market share of data center supply may elevate pricing pressures

RATINGS DEFINITIONS, BENCHMARKS AND DISTRIBUTION

EQUITY RATINGS DEFINITIONS

Bernstein brand

The Bernstein brand rates stocks based on forecasts of relative performance for the next 12 months versus the S&P 500 for stocks listed on the U.S. and Canadian exchanges, versus the Bloomberg Europe Developed Markets Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index EUR (EDME) for stocks listed on the European exchanges and emerging markets exchanges outside of the Asia Pacific region, versus the Bloomberg Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index USD (JPL) for stocks listed on the Japanese exchanges, and versus the Bloomberg Asia ex-Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index (ASIAX) for stocks listed on the Asian (ex-Japan) exchanges -unless otherwise specified.

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- Market-Perform: Stock will perform in line with the market index to within +/-15 pp

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Not Covered (NC) denotes companies that are not under coverage.

Bernstein brand stock ratings are based on a 12-month time horizon.

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- Neutral (N): The total return of the preferred instrument is expected to perform in line with preferred securities of other issuers operating in similar sectors or rating categories over the next six months.

- Underperform (UP): The total return of the preferred instrument is expected to underperform preferred securities of other issuers operating in similar sectors or rating categories over the next six months.

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Market-Perform (Bernstein Brand) Neutral (Autonomous Brand)	HOLD	36.3%	17.8%
Underperform	SELL	12.6%	14.9%

* These figures represent the percentage of companies within each equity rating category for which affiliates of Bernstein have provided investment banking services within the previous 12 months.
As of March 31, 2026. All figures are updated quarterly.

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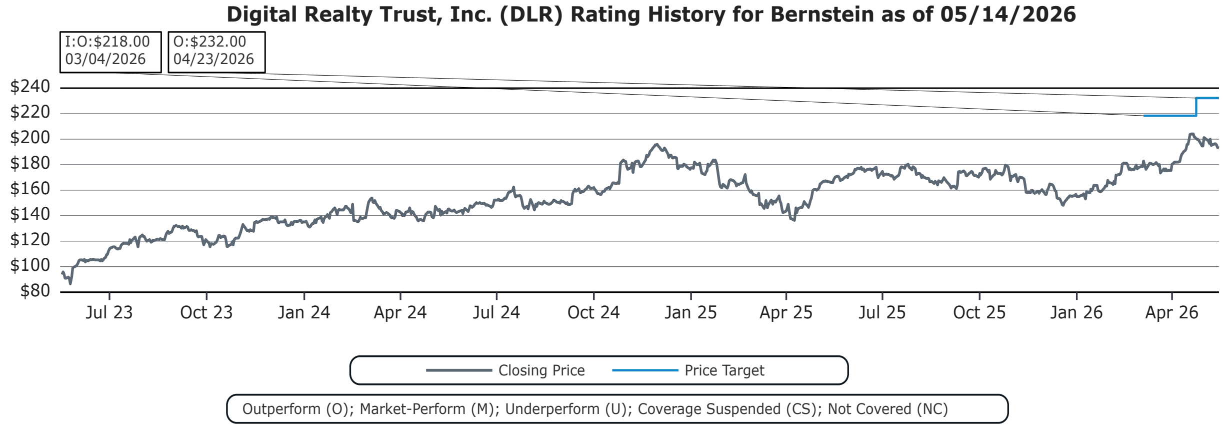

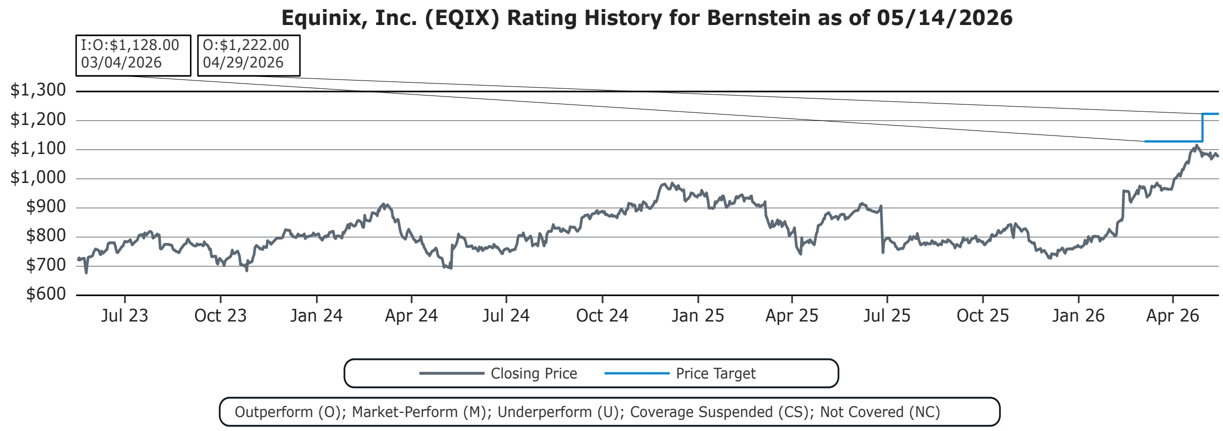

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